

Politics of Appearance

A Matched-Identity Candidate Experiment in Finland and Chile

Outi Sarpila · Héctor Bahamonde · Nayssa Alejandra Marín Díaz

Abstract. Citizens routinely encounter political candidates first as images. This study identifies whether modifiable political self-presentation—clothing, grooming, hair arrangement, and accessories—causally shapes candidate choice and trait evaluation, and whether those effects depend on congruence with stated policy. Four fictional Finnish identities are each rendered in progressive-coded, neutral, and conservative-coded forms while identity, expression, pose, lighting, age, and background remain fixed. In two paired municipal-election tasks, appearance, economic policy, and sociocultural policy are independently randomized. The design therefore separates an appearance effect from stable facial identity and from the political information attached to the image.

Prototype: political-appearance-finland.onrender.com

Motivation and contribution

Facial and bodily appearance can serve as a “heuristic” (Tversky and Kahneman, 1974), a rapid (political) cue, particularly when information is limited. Yet appearance is not a neutral measurement device: attractiveness and competence create halo effects in perceived ideology (Herrmann and Shikano, 2016); stereotypically conservative-looking faces can affect candidate support (Olivola et al., 2018); and a dominant-looking face can help with conservative audiences while backfiring among liberals (Laustsen and Petersen, 2016). Appearance also communicates social position. In Finnish municipal elections, upper-class-looking candidates received more votes, while working-class-looking women faced a distinctive penalty (Bahamonde and Sarpila, 2024). These findings imply that the same look need not be universally advantageous. Its meaning should depend on the political message, the audience, and the status boundaries active in a society.

This experiment advances this literature by manipulating *self-presentation within identity*. It asks whether politically coded appearance changes (i) vote choice; (ii) trustworthiness, competence, credibility, authenticity, and political suitability; (iii) perceived ideology; and (iv) perceived appearance–policy fit. Independent randomization turns a multidimensional image-and-policy profile into a “visual” conjoint experimental design (Hainmueller et al., 2014; Vecchiato and Munger, 2025). Unlike a text-only profile-like conjoint design, the treatment in the current design preserves the visual mode in which candidates are commonly encountered.

Design and hypotheses

Four identity-locked portrait triptychs yield $4 \times 3 = 12$ image files. Respondents see two nonrepeating pairs: identities 1–2 in Task 1 and identities 3–4 in Task 2. Appearance $A \in \{-1, 0, +1\}$ denotes progressive-coded, neutral, or conservative-coded presentation. Economic policy $E \in \{-1, +1\}$ and sociocultural policy $S \in \{-1, +1\}$ are independently randomized, as are screen side and the profile rated after each forced-choice vote (see Figure 1).

H1: Appearance shifts perceived ideology after policy information is shown. **H2:** appearance–platform congruence increases vote probability, credibility, authenticity, political suitability, and perceived fit. **H3:** effects vary with respondent ideology, class, knowledge, candidate gender, and country.

Causal logic

For respondent i , candidate j , and task t , let $Y_{ijt}(a, e, s)$ denote a potential outcome under appearance a , economic policy e , and sociocultural policy s , with identity j held fixed. The appearance AMCE relative to neutral is

$$\tau_a = \mathbb{E}_{E,S,J,T}[Y_{ijt}(a, E, S) - Y_{ijt}(0, E, S)], \quad a \in \{-1, +1\}.$$

For coherent platforms, let $P = -1$ denote economic-left/cultural-liberal and $P = +1$ economic-right/cultural-conservative. The appearance–platform interaction is

$$\tau_G = \{\mu(+1, +1) - \mu(-1, +1)\} - \{\mu(+1, -1) - \mu(-1, -1)\},$$

where $\mu(a, p) = \mathbb{E}[Y \mid A = a, P = p]$. Random assignment identifies both quantities; standard errors cluster by respondent and identity in the comparative study.

Experimental contribution

The experiment uses identity-matched images, independently randomizes appearance and two policy dimensions, prevents within-person identity repetition, randomizes the rated profile, and exports every assignment with choice time and outcomes.

Before fielding, a Finnish pretest must assess perceived ideology, class/status, attractiveness, apparent age, gender expression, realism, AI artifacts, and resemblance to real people. Selection rules and exclusions should be preregistered: synthetic faces can appear unusually trustworthy (Nightingale and Farid, 2022), while generators can reproduce stereotypes and homogenize groups (AlDahoul et al., 2025).

Why it matters

The design distinguishes appearance from facial identity and tests whether visual presentation corroborates or contradicts political substance. Scaling the identity pool in Finland and Chile reveals whether political appearance is a shared heuristic or a context-dependent route through which classed and gendered boundaries enter representation.

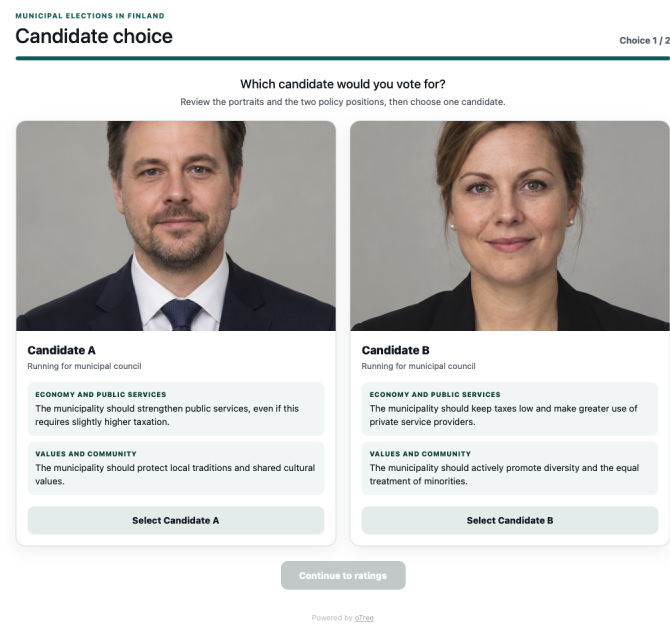
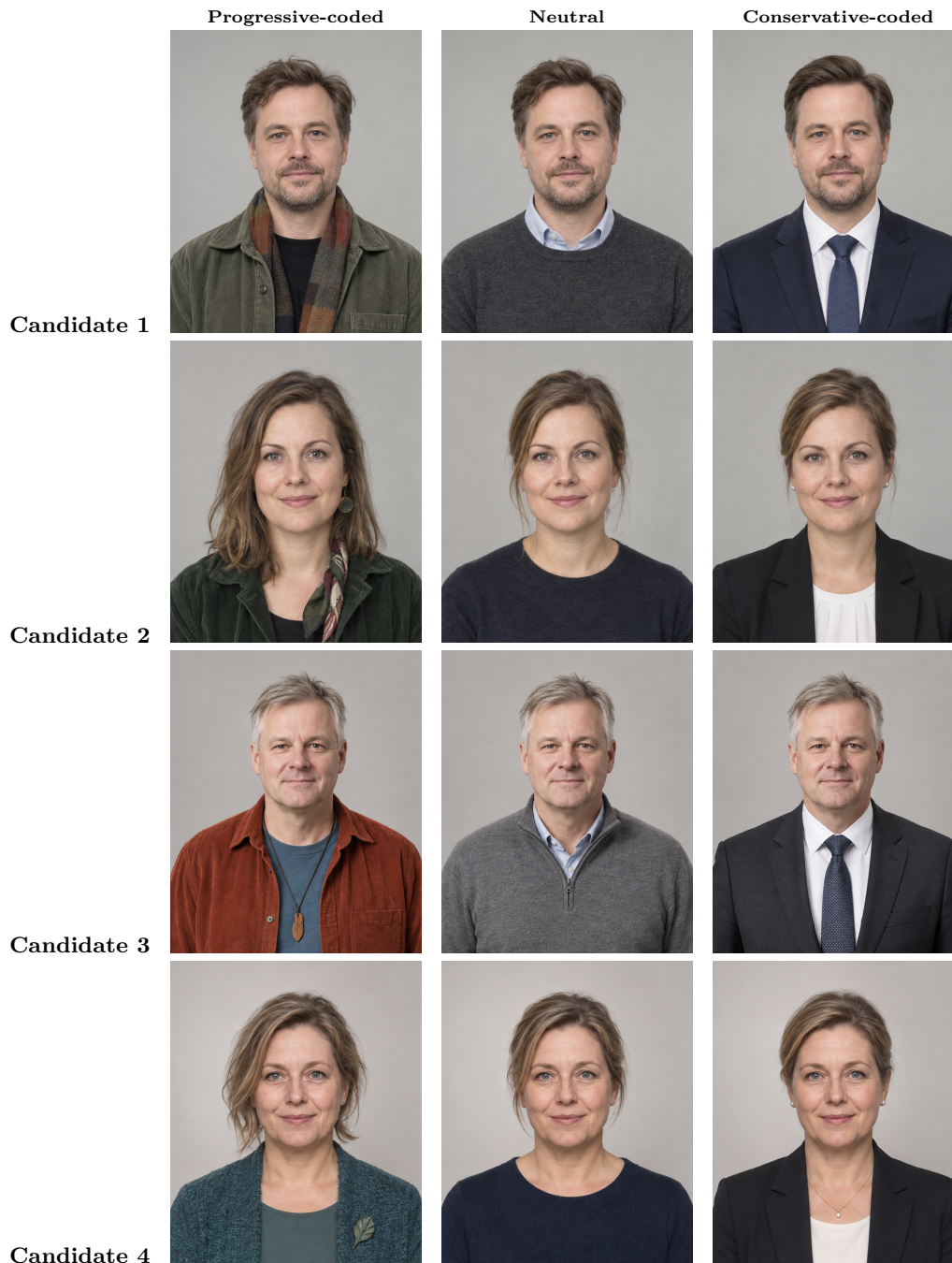


Figure 1: Candidate-choice task interface (example of one randomization).

Candidate appearance stimuli



Four identity-matched candidates across all three appearance conditions. The crop emphasizes the face, hair, accessories, and upper-body presentation used as visual cues.

References

- AlDahoul, N., Rahwan, T., & Zaki, Y. (2025). AI-generated faces influence gender stereotypes and racial homogenization. *Scientific Reports*, 15, 14449. doi:10.1038/s41598-025-99623-3.
- Bahamonde, H., & Sarpila, O. (2024). Physical appearance and elections: An inequality perspective. *Political Psychology*, 45, 623–642. doi:10.1111/pops.12940.
- Hainmueller, J., Hopkins, D. J., & Yamamoto, T. (2014). Causal inference in conjoint analysis. *Political Analysis*, 22, 1–30. doi:10.1093/pan/mpt024.
- Herrmann, M., & Shikano, S. (2016). Attractiveness and facial competence bias face-based inferences of candidate ideology. *Political Psychology*, 37, 401–417. doi:10.1111/pops.12256.
- Laustsen, L., & Petersen, M. B. (2016). Winning faces vary by ideology. *Political Communication*, 33, 188–211. doi:10.1080/10584609.2015.1050565.
- Nightingale, S. J., & Farid, H. (2022). AI-synthesized faces are indistinguishable from real faces and more trustworthy. *PNAS*, 119, e2120481119. doi:10.1073/pnas.2120481119.
- Olivola, C. Y., Tingley, D., & Todorov, A. (2018). Republican voters prefer candidates who have conservative-looking faces. *Political Psychology*, 39, 1157–1171. doi:10.1111/pops.12489.
- Vecchiato, A., & Munger, K. (2025). Introducing the visual conjoint. *Journal of Experimental Political Science*, 12, 57–71. doi:10.1017/XPS.2024.15.
- Tversky, A., & Kahneman, D. (1974). Judgment under uncertainty: Heuristics and biases. *Science*, 185(4157), 1124–1131. doi:10.1126/science.185.4157.1124.